

had contested and lost narrowly to Shashi Tharoor in the Thiruvananthapuram LS seat—as state unit chief. Sources say the move to bring in an outsider was done in consultation with the local as well as national Sangh leadership in a bid to resolve differences in the faction-ridden state unit and widen the voter base. The Sangh is also helping the BJP in its outreach efforts among the Catholic groups in the state.

In Bihar, the BJP will possibly go without a chief ministerial face, as it had done in Maharashtra. This should also help curtail the anti-incumbency against chief minister Nitish Kumar. Meanwhile, the Sangh's footsoldiers are working with the BJP to balance the caste equations. Here, as in Maharashtra, the Sangh hopes to tweak the Hindutva model so that it is not just associated with a party but with a larger cultural and social movement—one that remains stable even if political alignments change. This had helped the Sangh undercut the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) in Maharashtra, where the Sena is considered the most vocal proponent of Hindutva. Sangh sources stress that "ideological alignment is not the same as ideological ownership", which is why when Uddhav Thackeray shifted alliances, there was a quiet realignment of loyalties. In Bihar, the Sangh and its affiliates are apparently working on the plan of a "subtle but overarching Hindutva, with *samrasta* (harmony) as the agenda".

Similarly, in West Bengal, all the Sangh affiliates have been activated, right from the Vanvasi Kalyan Ashram to the Bharatiya Kisan Sangh and the student units of the ABVP. The BJP's prospects had suffered a jolt here in 2024, the Sangh's hands-off approach being one of them. Now reconciled, the party is looking at ways to add 6-7 per cent to its 2021 assembly poll vote share of 38 per cent. A part of the plan is to use the Sangh network to mobilise a 'Sant Pravas', an outreach initiative to rope in religious and spiritual leaders from across Bengal. Religious groups don't campaign directly, but they could build the narrative among their respective communities.

The Epiphany

Sangh sources point out that all these corrections came after the jolt the BJP received in the 2024 Lok Sabha election, when it fell short of a majority mark on its own and had to depend on allies like Nitish's Janata Dal (United) and N. Chandrababu Naidu's Telugu Desam Party to form the government. At the various post-poll introspection meetings, the BJP leadership admitted that the Hindutva consciousness prevalent among middle-class voters today wasn't built overnight. It took years of conversations, ideological shaping and careful cultivation of opinion leaders to create an environment where political shifts become inevitable rather than orchestrated. BJP sources admit the Sangh has played a crucial role in this. This was boosted, of course, by Modi's popularity and his unapologetic Hindutva, which went down well with many sections of society.

THE BJP LEADERSHIP SAYS THEY REALISE THE HINDUTVA CONSCIOUSNESS NOW PREVALENT AMONG MIDDLE-CLASS VOTERS WASN'T BUILT OVERNIGHT. THE SANGH PLAYED A CRUCIAL ROLE IN IT

The same was true of the assembly elections in Haryana, Maharashtra and Delhi where there was no wave in favour of the BJP. The electoral wins were the result of a steady undercurrent, a methodical effort that made certain ideas part of the cultural default. The Sangh played a role on the ground and the BJP was the ultimate beneficiary. After a run where the party was breaking speed records routinely, it was inevitable that a time would come when they had to take the foot off the pedal, slow down and acknowledge the engineers who made it all possible. For the BJP, that would be the Sangh Parivar. PM Modi's visit to Nagpur was a grateful acknowledgement of the same. ■